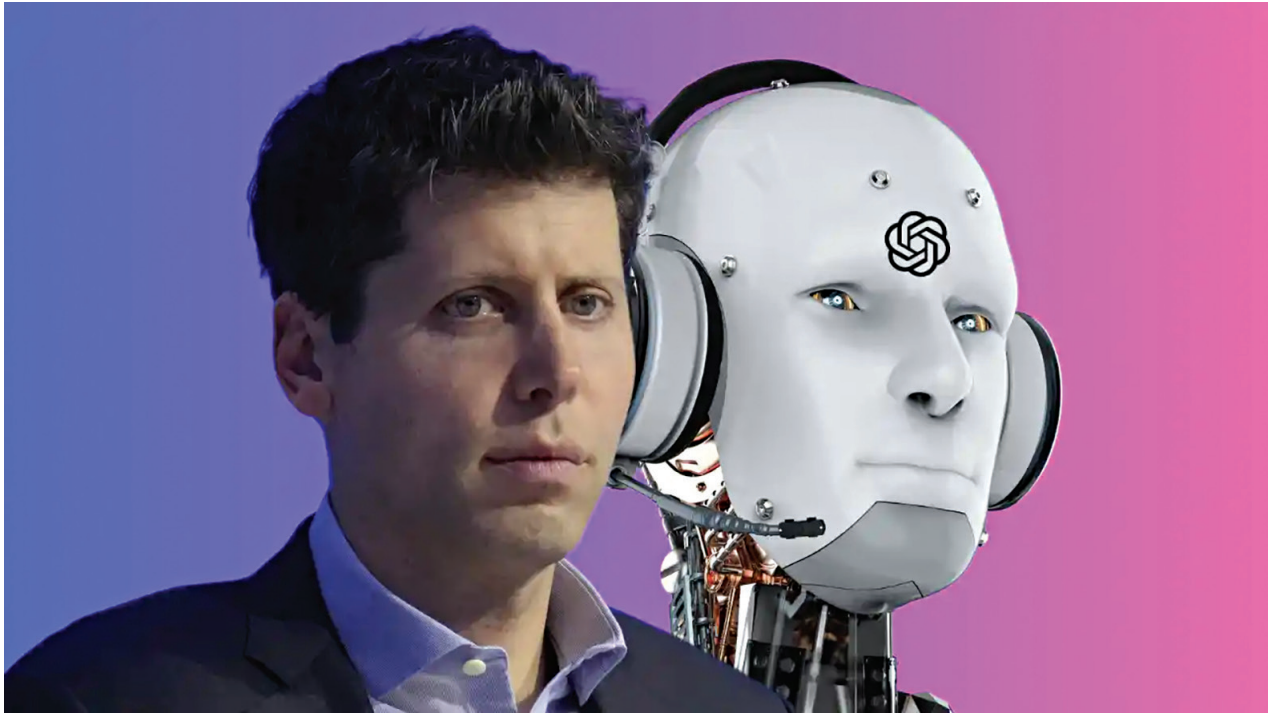




Future of work or AI hype?

OpenAI's PhD-research AI agent for \$20000 a month

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In the latest buzz on how fast technology's transforming our day-to-day grind, OpenAI's planning to launch a whole host of advanced "AI agents". These new offerings won't look much like the ChatGPT Free or Plus we've come to rely on for quick Q&A. Instead, OpenAI is taking AI to new extremes with specialized agents having specialized skill sets, according to The Information.

Not to be confused with the 'Deep Research' feature OpenAI launched

earlier in February 2025, which is an AI-driven tool that empowers ChatGPT to perform extensive research and deep-dive into a topic much better than your garden variety of ChatGPT response. With these upcoming specialized AI agents, we're talking about an agent for "high-income knowledge workers" at around \$2,000 a month, a developer-specific bot priced near \$10,000 a month, and a show-stopping \$20,000-a-month "PhD-level research" agent – roughly the yearly salary of some real PhDs out there.

That's not just a steep price tag, it's a statement of clear intent from OpenAI. If you want elite AI for high-stakes tasks, get ready to spend big.

OpenAI's new elite AI agents are super expensive

Let's entertain the idea that an AI agent truly does the heavy lifting on an entire software cycle, or helps a data analyst churn out insights that ordinarily require a team of six. If those gains are real, a \$10,000 monthly outlay might be peanuts for a well-funded startup or Fortune 500 company. That's especially true if the agent can handle specialized tasks that free up human experts for more creative, strategic work.

If these specialized AI agents truly deliver on their promise, we're talking about an AI that's not just automating mundane tasks, but stepping into territory once reserved for skilled professionals. That's the deeper conversation that we will need to have, eventually. If a \$20,000-a-month AI agent can replicate or augment the output